Letter Writing

The big idea

In the CBSE Class 10 exam you write one **formal letter** (about **100–120 words**, 5 marks) — a letter of **complaint**, **enquiry**, **placing an order**, or a **letter to the editor**. Marks are given for **format**, **content**, **organisation** and **accuracy**, so a correct layout alone can earn you easy marks.

The standard format

FORMAL LETTER LAYOUT (TOP TO BOTTOM, ALL LEFT-ALIGNED)

1. **Sender's address** (in the exam use "Examination Hall" or the given address)
2. **Date** (e.g. 18 October 20XX)
3. **Receiver's designation and address** (The Manager, ABC Books, …)
4. **Subject:** one line, to the point
5. **Salutation:** Sir / Madam (or Dear Sir / Madam)
6. **Body:** 3 paragraphs — introduction (purpose), details, conclusion (request/action expected)
7. **Complimentary close:** Yours faithfully / Yours sincerely
8. **Signature, name** (and designation if given)

USE THE NAME GIVEN IN THE QUESTION

If the question says "You are Rohan/Rohini of 12, MG Road", sign with **that name and address** — do not write your own. Also, never write "Yours

faithfully" with a comma error or "Your's".

Language tips

- Be **polite, formal and concise**; no slang, contractions or emotional outbursts.
- Start with the purpose: *I am writing to draw your attention to… / I wish to enquire about… / I would like to place an order for…*
- End with action: *I hope you will take prompt action. / I look forward to an early reply.*
- Use passive and formal phrases: *It has been observed that…; Kindly…; I would be grateful if…*

Types of formal letters

1. Letter of complaint — to a company, shop or official about a defective product, poor service or civic problem. Include: what was bought/what the problem is, when, bill/order number, the inconvenience caused, and what you want (replacement, refund, repair, action).

2. Letter of enquiry — to ask for information (courses, tours, admissions, products). Include: what you want to know in clear points (fees, duration, eligibility, facilities) and a request for a brochure/early reply.

3. Letter placing an order — to a supplier. Include: a **table/list** of items with quantity and specifications, mode of payment, delivery date and address, discount if any, and a request to send items in good condition.

4. Letter to the editor — to raise public awareness about an issue (stray animals, noise pollution, water-logging). Begin with *Through the columns of your esteemed newspaper, I wish to…*; describe the problem, causes, effects and suggestions.

MODEL LETTER OF COMPLAINT

Examination Hall
ABC Nagar, Delhi
18 October 20XX

The Manager
Smart Electronics
Karol Bagh, New Delhi

Subject: Complaint regarding a defective water purifier

Sir

I am writing to complain about the water purifier (Model AquaPure X2, Bill No. 4512) that I purchased from your store on 5 October 20XX.

Within a week of installation, the purifier began leaking and the filtered water has an unpleasant smell. Despite two calls to your service centre, no technician has visited. This has caused great inconvenience, as my family now has to buy bottled water.

As the product is under warranty, I request you to replace it or refund the amount at the earliest. A copy of the bill is enclosed. I hope for a prompt response.

Yours faithfully
Rohan

OPENING LINES TO REMEMBER

- Enquiry: *I came across your advertisement in The Hindu dated… offering a summer course in robotics. I would be grateful if you could provide the following details.*
- Order: *I would like to place an order for the following books for our school library.*
- Editor: *Through the columns of your esteemed daily, I wish to draw the attention of the authorities towards the menace of stray dogs in our locality.*

SCORING CHECKLIST

Correct format (with subject) ✓ · Purpose in the first line ✓ · All details from the question used ✓ · Three clear paragraphs ✓ · Polite closing with action requested ✓ · 100–120 words ✓

Quick recap

- Sender's address → date → receiver's address → subject → salutation → body (3 paras) → Yours faithfully → name.
- Complaint: problem + details + demand. Enquiry: list of questions. Order: list of items + delivery terms. Editor: issue + effects + suggestions.
- Formal, concise and polite; use the name and address given.

Practice questions

1. In a formal letter, what comes immediately after the date?
   (a) The subject (b) The salutation (c) The receiver's address (d) The signature
2. Which complimentary close is most suitable for a formal letter to a company?
   (a) Your loving friend (b) Lots of love (c) Yours faithfully (d) Cheers
3. A letter asking a coaching institute about fees and course duration is a letter of
   (a) complaint (b) enquiry (c) order (d) apology
4. Which opening is best for a letter to the editor?
   (a) Hi editor, how are you? (b) I am very angry today. (c) Through the columns of your esteemed newspaper, I wish to draw attention to… (d) Please print my letter quickly.
5. Which detail is essential in a letter placing an order?
   (a) A joke to build rapport (b) Your hobbies (c) The editor's name (d) A list of items with quantities and delivery terms
6. What is the usual word limit for the formal letter in the CBSE Class 10 exam?
   (a) 50–60 words (b) 100–120 words (c) 200–250 words (d) 300 words
7. Which part states the purpose of the letter in one line, before the salutation?
   (a) The complimentary close (b) The subject line (c) The sender's address (d) The date
8. You are Riya/Rahul of 14, Lake Road, Kolkata. Write a letter to the Manager, Book World, Park Street, Kolkata, placing an order for books for your school library. (100–120 words)

Answers: 1. c 2. c 3. b 4. c 5. d 6. b 7. b 8. see notes